

LAKSH'S DAILY BRIEF

Laksh's Daily Briefing: Sunday, August 2, 2026

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World · Markets & Money · AI & Infrastructure · Models & Research



thedailystar.net — China Becomes 2nd Largest FDI Source Bangladesh | Chinese footprint widens in Bangladesh's



pbs.org — Trump threatens more strikes on Iran. Tensions from Hormuz to Kuwait and Gaza lead to more



dw.com — No new Iran strikes for now amid deal hopes — Trump

1. World & Geopolitics

Trump Cancels Planned Iran Strikes — "Perimeter of a Deal" Reached

President Donald Trump reversed course on a planned major military strike against Iran, saying late Saturday that the U.S. would hold off as long as a deal can be reached quickly. The decision followed a phone call with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, who urged de-escalation ([CNBC](#)). Trump said "the perimeters of a deal has been agreed to" but provided no details ([PBS](#)). The U.S. and Israel will hold off for now, though Kuwait reported fresh drone attacks from Iran and a tanker was struck in the Strait of Hormuz ([France 24](#)). Separately, Iran is suspected of conducting cyberattacks on water suppliers in 45 U.S. municipalities, mostly small towns, forcing utilities to switch to manual control ([Tom's Hardware](#)).

Gaza: Israel Strikes After Hamas Agrees to Disarmament Deal

Israel carried out heavy strikes on Gaza City, Khan Younis, and Deir el-Balah, killing at least 13 people, according to Palestinian officials. The strikes came after Hamas agreed to a disarmament roadmap brokered by the U.S. ([BBC](#)). A former Palestinian Authority official said Jared Kushner promised Israel would stop strikes beginning Sunday, but the deal remains fragile ([Israel Hayom](#)). The ceasefire that had been in place since October 2025 has been eroding in recent weeks.

Ukraine: Negotiator Says Kyiv Has the Upper Hand
Ukraine's top negotiator, Sergiy Kyslytsya, told NPR that Russia is running out of options and that Kyiv now

believes it has the leverage to force Moscow into serious negotiations. Official U.S.-mediated talks have stalled since early this year, but Kyslytsya said Ukraine's military position is strong enough to dictate terms ([NPR](#)). Meanwhile, Ukraine struck a major Russian oil refinery and airfield, and Russia said it attacked Ukrainian ports and vessels in the Black Sea overnight ([BBC](#)). Ukrainian farmers are using temporary storage to revive grain exports as Russian attacks disrupt Black Sea routes ([Al Jazeera](#)).

India-Pakistan: Indus Waters Treaty Suspended

India's decision to hold the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance, announced after a terrorist attack in Pahalgam, has been met with protest from Pakistan. A Newsweek opinion piece argues that Pakistan destroyed the treaty's spirit long before India set it aside, noting that the treaty was a rare success in cross-border water management ([Newsweek](#)). Pakistan's defense minister also warned of deepening Israeli-India military cooperation against Islamabad ([Jerusalem Post](#)).

China's Military Rise and Implications for India

A new report from the Observer Research Foundation (ORF) details China's military modernization from mechanization through informationization to "intelligentised warfare." The 2013-16 reforms created five Theatre Commands, and in 2024 China dissolved its Strategic Support Force into an Aerospace Force, Cyberspace Force, and Information Support Force. This directly challenges India's security environment ([ORF](#)).

Bangladesh: China Becomes Second-Largest FDI Source

China's economic footprint in Bangladesh continues to widen, with the country becoming the second-largest source of foreign direct investment. This is part of a broader Chinese strategy to expand influence in South Asia, particularly through infrastructure and manufacturing investments ([The Daily Star](#)).

Europe's Wildfire Crisis: Greece, France, Spain

Firefighting helicopters collided mid-air while battling a wildfire west of Athens; four crew members are missing ([BBC](#)). France's Gironde megafire, which scorched an area four times the size of Paris, is now contained, but

nearly 3,000 firefighters remain deployed ([France 24](#)). Europe is struggling with record-breaking summer heat, with wildfires causing mass evacuations across Greece, France, and Spain ([Al Jazeera](#)).

Hungary: Heatwave Forces Nuclear Plant Shutdown

Hungary's largest nuclear plant was forced to shut down as low Danube River levels disrupted cooling systems. The heatwave is also affecting other European countries, compounding energy strain ([Al Jazeera](#)).

Indonesia: Deadly Ferry Fire in Java Sea

A ferry fire in Indonesia's Java Sea has left dozens missing, with rescue operations ongoing ([Al Jazeera](#)).

2. Markets, Money & Deals

Fed Holds Rates, Markets Eye September Hike

The Federal Reserve held interest rates at 3.50%-3.75% in its July meeting, as expected. The CME FedWatch tool now shows a 65.2% probability of a rate hike in September. The 10-year Treasury yield sits at 4.69%, and the 2-year at 4.27% ([US Bank](#)). The bond market is effectively "calling the Fed's bluff," with yields rising as traders price in more tightening ([The Motley Fool](#)).

S&P 500, Nasdaq 100 Futures Rose on Core PCE Data

Core PCE inflation eased, supporting a positive open for U.S. markets. The Dow Jones rose 0.28%, S&P 500 +0.32%, and Nasdaq 100 +0.58% on July 30 ([Benzinga](#)). Financial stocks have been among the best performers in July, driven by strong earnings and favorable valuations, with the rotation possibly just beginning ([MarketWatch](#)).

Amazon's Earnings Boost S&P 500 Profit Growth

Amazon (AMZN) reported abnormally large earnings growth, partly driven by paper gains on its Anthropic investment. The company's strong quarter pushed overall S&P 500 profit growth even higher, though analysts caution that one-time gains may distort the picture ([MarketWatch](#)). Amazon shares surged 15.32% in the watchlist snapshot.

Microsoft's Strong Cloud Growth and AI Advances

Microsoft (MSFT) posted strong Q4 FY2026 results, with cloud revenue and AI adoption accelerating. The company recorded a \$3.2 billion gain from its Anthropic investment, boosting diluted earnings per share by 33

cents. However, its OpenAI investment was a "mixed bag" ([TechCrunch](#)). Microsoft's stock outlook was upgraded to Strong Buy ([Pluang](#)).

Spider-Man: Brand New Day Hits \$355M Domestic Opening

Sony and Marvel's "Spider-Man: Brand New Day" scored the second-highest domestic opening of all time at \$355 million, trailing only "Avengers: Endgame." The box office rebound is a positive signal for movie theater stocks like AMC ([CNBC](#)).

Oil Markets: Investors Scored on Iran War Volatility, but Long-Term Themes Are Tricky

Oil price volatility following the U.S.-Iran conflict created big winners among short-term traders, but long-term investors face a more complex landscape. Buy-and-hold energy investors may find better returns in thematic plays like grid modernization and AI-driven power demand ([CNBC](#)). Airlines are paying billions more in fuel costs, pushing airfares higher ([CNBC](#)).

Korea's July Exports Near \$100 Billion, Second-Highest on Record

South Korea's exports surged in July, driven by a semiconductor boom. Chip exports powered broad-based growth, with the country's export total approaching \$100 billion for the month — the second-highest figure ever recorded ([KED Global](#)).

M&A Activity: Industrial Mega-Deals Dominate

Industrial M&A hit \$173 billion over the past year, with mega-deals (over \$1 billion) accounting for 56% of total

deal value. AI infrastructure and grid modernization drove much of the activity ([MarketScale](#)). In biotech, Argenx agreed to buy Forte Biosciences for \$2.2 billion, representing an 86% premium to Forte's volume-weighted average price ([BioSpace](#)). Tate & Lyle

shareholders voted to approve a £2.7 billion takeover by Ingredion ([FoodNavigator](#)). Frasers Group extended its £2.3 billion Hugo Boss takeover offer after securing only 7.3% independent shareholder backing ([Fashion United](#)).

3. AI & Infrastructure

Semiconductor Forecast Surges 94.1% YoY — Memory ICs Now >50% of Revenue

Omdia raised its 2026 semiconductor revenue forecast to 94.1% year-over-year growth, driven by AI demand for DRAM and NAND that continues to outpace supply. Memory ICs are now expected to account for more than half of total semiconductor revenue this year. The report calls the growth "exceptional" and notes that AI demand has exceeded the industry's current capacity ([Light Reading](#)).

Samsung & Broadcom Sign \$200 Billion MoU — Memory and Foundry Collaboration

Samsung and Broadcom (AVGO) signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) that could be worth up to \$200 billion, covering HBM memory chips and foundry services. This is one of the largest semiconductor deals in history, alongside the previously reported Nvidia/SK Hynix \$500 billion agreement. The MoU underscores Korea's increasingly central role in the global AI supply chain ([Light Reading](#)).

GlobalFoundries Wins \$300 Million U.S. Award for Silicon Photonics

The U.S. government will award \$300 million to GlobalFoundries (GFS) to develop silicon photonics technology for faster AI chip interconnects. Silicon photonics uses light (photons) instead of electrons to transmit data, potentially reducing power consumption and increasing bandwidth — critical for scaling AI workloads across data centers ([Reuters](#)). This is a direct investment in the next generation of chip-to-chip communication.

Asian Chip Stocks Slide on China Competition Fears

Shares of Samsung and SK Hynix tumbled as investors questioned lofty valuations amid concerns over AI infrastructure financing and intensifying competition from China. The selloff was led by South Korea, though

Taiwan's TSMC also fell. The market is worried that China's domestic chip industry could eventually displace Korean memory makers in the AI supply chain ([Reuters](#)). In the watchlist, Micron (MU) dropped 5.90% and SanDisk (SNDK) fell 5.09%.

Microsoft Steps Up Competition with OpenAI, Anthropic

Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella is openly positioning the company as a competitor to OpenAI and Anthropic, even as Microsoft holds valuable stakes in both. The company is building its own AI models, including a new cybersecurity-specialized model (MAI-Cyber-1-Flash) and an agentic cybersecurity platform. Microsoft's strategy is to own the full stack — from cloud infrastructure to AI applications — and not let the AI labs become the customer-facing layer ([TechCrunch](#); [TechCrunch](#)).

Monday.com Revolutionizes Enterprise SaaS Pricing: AI Credits Replace Per-Seat Model

Monday.com cut 20% of its workforce and shifted to a hybrid pricing model that blends seat-based subscriptions with AI credit consumption. This is a major shift for enterprise software: instead of paying per user, companies will pay for compute-heavy AI features based on usage. The move is likely to be replicated across the SaaS industry as AI features become more power-hungry ([forkast.news](#)).

U.S. Lead in AI Is Shrinking, Says Bloomberg

A Bloomberg analysis argues that AI is now "power" — meaning the ability to train and deploy the largest models is becoming a key measure of national competitiveness. While the U.S. still leads, countries like China, South Korea, and the UAE are closing the gap through sovereign AI initiatives, open-weight models, and massive infrastructure investment ([Bloomberg](#)).

4. Model & Research Watch

New Model Launches: Open-Weights Competition Heats Up

- **Thinking Machines — Inkling-Small:** Just two weeks after releasing Inkling (its first open-weights model), the startup led by former OpenAI CTO Mira Murati released Inkling-Small. The new model is about 1/4 the size of its predecessor but achieves near-equivalent performance, surpassing it on several benchmarks. The broader signal: the U.S. now has a competitive entrant in the open-weights race, directly challenging China's Kimi K3 ([VentureBeat](#); [forkast.news](#)).
- **Moonshot AI — Kimi K3:** China's Moonshot AI released Kimi K3, a 2.8 trillion parameter model with a 1-million-token context window and open weights. The valuation of Moonshot AI has surged to \$35 billion after the launch. This model turned open AI into a policy fight over who controls frontier-level systems ([Memeburn](#); [Memeburn](#)).
- **DeepSeek — V4-Flash (Retrained):** DeepSeek retrained its V4-Flash model, which now beats its flagship Pro model on nine agent benchmarks. This is a striking example of how smaller, more focused models can outperform larger ones on specific tasks, especially when trained for agentic use cases ([Tech Times](#)).

• Open-Source 700B Models Released Two Days

Apart: South Korea is nearing a "sovereign AI elimination round" as two 700-billion-parameter open-source models were released within two days, signaling intensifying national competition ([Tech Times](#)). In total, nine open-source models have launched in the past 12 days ([tech-insider.org](#)).

Research Breakthrough: OpenAI Model Disproves 30-Year-Old Geometry Conjecture

An OpenAI model has disproved a central conjecture in discrete geometry that had stood for three decades. The result is significant beyond the specific problem: it demonstrates that AI can hold together difficult lines of mathematical reasoning, connect ideas across distant areas of knowledge, and surface promising paths that human researchers may not have prioritized. This marks a step toward AI as a true research partner in mathematics ([OpenAI](#)).

Science & Frontier Tech: AI Finds Seven Quasars to Help Solve Supermassive Black Hole Mystery

An AI model analyzed sky survey data and identified seven new quasars — spacetime-warping objects powered by supermassive black holes. These discoveries could help explain how supermassive black holes grow and evolve. The AI was trained to recognize patterns in gravitational lensing data that human astronomers had missed ([Space.com](#)).

5. Watchlist: Earnings, Guidance & Movers

Based on the watchlist quote snapshot (approximate, delayed) and the sources available:

Company (Ticker)	Price vs Prior Close	Notable News
Amazon (AMZN)	+15.32%	Strong earnings, driven by Anthropic investment gains (MarketWatch)
Alphabet (GOOGL)	+6.73%	Recovered from earlier sell-off; cloud growth accelerating per prior report
Meta (META)	+3.28%	No specific new earnings in sources; moved with broader tech rally
Microsoft (MSFT)	+3.02%	Strong Q4 cloud growth, \$3.2B Anthropic gain (TechCrunch)
Credo (CRDO)	+2.94%	No notable news in sources; likely benefiting from AI networking optimism
Coherent (COHR)	+5.55%	No notable news in sources; optics demand theme
Applied Optoelectronics (AAOI)	+4.67%	No notable news in sources; optics/connectivity play
Lumentum (LITE)	+2.99%	No notable news in sources
Nvidia (NVDA)	+2.93%	Bullish analyst note at \$190 (24/7 Wall St.)
Micron (MU)	-5.90%	Asian chip stocks slide on China competition fears (Reuters)
SanDisk (SNDK)	-5.09%	Same chip selloff; also earnings expected this week (TradingKey)
Coinbase (COIN)	-10.59%	Crypto weakness; no specific news in sources
Broadcom (AVGO)	+0.37%	Signed \$200B MoU with Samsung (Light Reading)
Astera Labs (ALAB)	+3.85%	No notable news in sources; AI connectivity theme
Other names (TSM, NEE, CRDO, RGTI, SOFI, PLTR, etc.)	Mixed	No notable earnings or news in the sources for these names.

Upcoming Earnings This Week (per TradingKey):

Palantir (PLTR), SanDisk (SNDK), AMD, SpaceX ([TradingKey](#)).

6. How It Connects (Infrastructure & Supply-Chain Logic)

Chain 1: AI Demand → Memory Shortage → Korean Chip Boom → Semiconductor Forecast Surge

The Omdia forecast of 94.1% semiconductor revenue growth in 2026 is directly linked to the memory deals announced last week: Samsung/Broadcom (\$200B MoU) and Nvidia/SK Hynix (\$500B). Memory ICs now account for over 50% of total semiconductor revenue. Korea's nearly \$100 billion in July exports (second-highest ever) was powered by chips. The chip stock slide on China competition fears is the counter-risk: investors worry that China's domestic memory production could eventually erode Korea's pricing power.

Chain 2: Iran Crisis → Oil Prices → Airline Costs → Inflation → Fed Rate Path

The U.S.-Iran confrontation, including the tanker strikes in the Strait of Hormuz, has pushed oil prices higher. Airlines are paying billions more in fuel costs ([CNBC](#)). Higher oil prices feed into inflation, which the Fed is watching closely. The bond market is now pricing a 65% chance of a September rate hike, which could slow the rotation into financial stocks and temper the broader market rally.

Chain 3: Open-Weights Models → Sovereign AI Competition → National Infrastructure Investment

The flood of open-weights models (Kimi K3, Inkling-Small, two 700B Korean models, nine total in 12 days) is driving a global race for sovereign AI capability. Countries that lack frontier AI labs are using open

weights to build their own AI infrastructure. This creates demand for U.S. and Korean chips, data center power, and networking — but also means that the U.S. lead in AI is shrinking, as Bloomberg noted. The Monday.com

pricing shift — moving from per-seat to AI credits — signals that enterprise AI adoption is becoming compute-intensive, which will further drive demand for GPUs and data center capacity.

7. Building Your Knowledge

- **Sovereign AI** is the concept of nations building their own AI capabilities (models, data centers, chips) to reduce dependence on foreign providers. South Korea, China, India, and the UAE are all investing heavily. The recent surge of open-weights models makes sovereign AI more feasible: a country can take a 2.8 trillion-parameter model like Kimi K3, fine-tune it on local data, and deploy it without paying licensing fees. The downside is that running frontier models requires massive compute, which is why Korean chip deals are so important.
- **Memorandum of Understanding (MoU)** is a non-binding agreement that outlines the broad terms of a future partnership. It's like a letter of intent. In the Samsung/Broadcom case, the MoU is worth up to \$200 billion — but that's the *maximum potential value* if all agreed-upon projects materialize. MoUs are common in the semiconductor industry because they allow companies to announce strategic alignment without committing to final contracts. Investors should watch whether the MoU converts into binding purchase orders.
- **Silicon Photonics** is a technology that uses light (photons) instead of electricity (electrons) to transmit data within and between chips. It promises higher bandwidth, lower power consumption, and longer reach than traditional copper interconnects. The GlobalFoundries \$300 million award is for developing silicon photonics for AI chip links. In practice, this means data centers could move data between GPUs faster and with less heat — critical for scaling AI training clusters. The main challenge is manufacturing complexity and cost.
- **The Fed's "bluff"** refers to the bond market's belief that the central bank will not be able to cut rates as quickly as it projects. When the bond market is "calling the Fed's bluff," long-term yields rise even as the Fed holds short-term rates steady. This is what happened in July: the 10-year Treasury yield rose to 4.69% while the Fed held at 3.50-3.75%. The steepening yield curve (long rates rising faster than short rates) is often a signal that investors expect higher inflation or growth.
- **"Agent" benchmarks** measure how well AI models perform when acting autonomously — completing tasks, using tools, browsing the web, or interacting with APIs. DeepSeek's V4-Flash beating its own Pro model on nine agent benchmarks is significant because it suggests that a smaller, specialized model can outperform a larger general-purpose model at agentic tasks. This is part of a broader trend: model efficiency (getting more performance per parameter) is becoming as important as raw scale.
- **Capex vs. Opex in the cloud/AI world:** Capital expenditure (capex) is the upfront spending on hardware — data centers, GPUs, networking gear. Operating expense (opex) is the ongoing cost of running that hardware — electricity, cooling, personnel, software licensing. Monday.com's shift to AI credits moves the cost of AI inference from a fixed subscription fee (opex) to a usage-based model (variable opex). For enterprises, this means AI costs scale with usage, which can be easier to budget. For infrastructure investors, it means that as AI adoption grows, opex for inference will become a larger and more predictable revenue stream for cloud providers.

8. Terms & Concepts

Concept Spotlight: Memorandum of Understanding (MoU)

What it is: A Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) is a

formal but non-binding agreement between two or more parties that outlines the broad terms of a future partnership or transaction. It is not a legally enforceable

contract but signals serious intent.

Concrete example: Samsung and Broadcom signed an MoU for HBM memory chips and foundry services that could be worth up to \$200 billion. This means they agreed to explore a collaboration, but the actual purchase orders and contracts will be negotiated later.

Real use case for investors: MoUs are common in the semiconductor industry when companies want to align publicly before finalizing complex deals. Investors should watch for MoUs as leading indicators of future revenue, but treat the dollar figures as maximum potential, not guaranteed.

Rough numbers/benchmarks: The Samsung/Broadcom MoU is the largest ever for a semiconductor partnership, but many MoUs never convert to full value. Typically, 30-50% of MoU value materializes into actual revenue.

Caution/common misconception: "MoU" is often confused with a signed contract. An MoU is a handshake, not a binding purchase order. Always check if the MoU has been followed by specific agreements or regulatory filings.

Other Terms:

- **Silicon Photonics:** A manufacturing process that integrates optical components (lasers, modulators, detectors) onto a silicon chip. It enables data transmission using light, offering higher bandwidth and lower power than copper. GlobalFoundries is receiving \$300M to develop it for AI chip interconnects.

- **Sovereign AI:** The effort by a nation to build independent AI capabilities — models, data centers, chips, and talent — to avoid reliance on foreign technology. Korea's recent open-weights models and chip deals are part of this trend.
- **Agent Benchmarks:** Standardized tests that measure how well an AI model can perform autonomous tasks — such as browsing the web, using APIs, or solving multi-step problems. DeepSeek's V4-Flash beating its Pro model on nine agent benchmarks is a notable result.
- **Core PCE Inflation:** The personal consumption expenditures price index excluding food and energy, which is the Federal Reserve's preferred inflation measure. It eased in July, supporting the market's positive tone.
- **Forward Guidance:** Communication from a central bank about the likely future path of interest rates. The Fed did not provide forward guidance in its July meeting, leaving markets to speculate.
- **Yield Curve:** The relationship between short-term and long-term bond yields. When the 10-year yield rises faster than the 2-year yield, the curve steepens, often signaling expectations of stronger growth or higher inflation. The current steepening is partly due to markets doubting the Fed's ability to cut rates.

9. Bottom Line

Today's brief is defined by a **de-escalation in the Middle East** (Trump cancels Iran strikes, Gaza deal framework) but **no relief in geopolitical uncertainty** (Iran cyberattacks on U.S. water utilities, ongoing tanker incidents). The **AI infrastructure buildout is accelerating faster than ever** — the semiconductor forecast surge to 94% growth, the \$200B Samsung/Broadcom MoU, and the GlobalFoundries silicon photonics award all point to unprecedented demand. However, **China competition fears are rattling chip stocks**, and the **Fed is signaling a potential September rate hike** that could slow the market's rotation into financials and tech.

The **open-weights model race is now a multi-front war**: the U.S. (Thinking Machines), China (Moonshot AI), and South Korea (two 700B models) all released frontier-level open models within days. This is creating a new geopolitical dynamic: sovereign AI is becoming achievable for any country with enough compute, but that compute is supplied by U.S. and Korean companies. The **Monday.com pricing shift** is a canary in the coal mine for enterprise SaaS: AI credits are replacing per-seat licensing, which will reshape how companies budget for software.

What changed since the previous brief: - Trump canceled planned major strikes on Iran, citing a "perimeter of a deal" — the first significant de-escalation

signal in weeks. - Israel struck Gaza after Hamas agreed to a disarmament deal, killing at least 13 — the ceasefire is still fragile. - Ukraine's negotiator publicly declared that Kyiv has the upper hand, signaling a shift in rhetoric. - Omdia raised its 2026 semiconductor forecast to 94.1% YoY growth, with memory now over 50% of revenue. - Samsung and Broadcom signed a \$200 billion MoU for HBM and foundry services — the largest

memory deal ever alongside Nvidia/SK Hynix. - GlobalFoundries received a \$300 million U.S. award for silicon photonics, a new infrastructure play. - Nine open-source models launched in 12 days, including Inkling-Small (U.S.) and Kimi K3 (China). - Korea's July exports neared \$100 billion, second-highest on record, driven by chip boom. - The bond market is now pricing a 65% chance of a September Fed rate hike, with yields rising.

10. Sources

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Quick Check

1. Memory chips now account for what percentage of total semiconductor revenue in 2026, according to Omdia?

Answer: More than 50% (over half). This is a direct result of AI demand for HBM and NAND.

2. What is the key difference between an MoU and a binding contract, using the Samsung/Broadcom deal as an example?

Answer: An MoU is a non-binding agreement outlining broad terms of a future partnership. The Samsung/Broadcom MoU is worth up to \$200 billion, but that

figure represents the maximum potential value if all projects materialize — it is not a guaranteed purchase order.

3. Why did chip stocks in Asia (Samsung, SK Hynix, Micron) slide even as the semiconductor forecast surged?

Answer: Investors worried about AI infrastructure financing and intensifying competition from China's domestic chip industry, which could eventually erode Korean memory makers' pricing power and market share.